

**HISTORICAL RECORD
OF THE
CAPE MOUNTED
RIFLEMEN.**

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THE CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN ***

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BY COMMAND OF His late Majesty WILLIAM THE IVTH.

and under the Patronage of
Her Majesty the Queen.

HISTORICAL RECORDS,
OF THE

British Army

Comprising the

History of every Regiment

IN HER MAJESTY'S SERVICE.

*By Richard Cannon Esq^{re}.
Adjutant General's Office, Horse Guards.
London.
Printed by Authority.
1837.*

HISTORICAL RECORDS
OF
THE BRITISH ARMY.

GENERAL ORDERS.

*HORSE-GUARDS,
1st January, 1836.*

His Majesty has been pleased to command, that, with a view of doing the fullest justice to Regiments, as well as to Individuals who have distinguished themselves by their Bravery in Action with the Enemy, an Account of the Services of every Regiment in the British Army shall be published under the superintendence and direction of the Adjutant-General; and that this Account shall contain the following particulars, viz.,

—— The Period and Circumstances of the Original Formation of the Regiment; The Stations at which it has been from time to time employed; The Battles, Sieges, and other Military Operations, in which it has been engaged, particularly specifying any Achievement it may have performed, and the Colours, Trophies, &c., it may have captured from the Enemy.

—— The Names of the Officers and the number of Non-Commissioned Officers and Privates, Killed or Wounded by the Enemy, specifying the Place and Date of the Action.

—— The Names of those Officers, who, in consideration of their Gallant Services and Meritorious Conduct in Engagements with the Enemy, have been distinguished with Titles, Medals, or other Marks of His Majesty's gracious favour.

—— The Names of all such Officers, Non-Commissioned Officers and Privates as may have specially signalized themselves in Action.

And,

—— The Badges and Devices which the Regiment may have been permitted to bear, and the Causes on account of which such Badges or

Devices, or any other Marks of Distinction, have been granted.

By Command of the Right Honourable
GENERAL LORD HILL,
Commanding-in-Chief.

JOHN MACDONALD,
Adjutant-General.

PREFACE.

The character and credit of the British Army must chiefly depend upon the zeal and ardour, by which all who enter into its service are animated, and consequently it is of the highest importance that any measure calculated to excite the spirit of emulation, by which alone great and gallant actions are achieved, should be adopted.

Nothing can more fully tend to the accomplishment of this desirable object, than a full display of the noble deeds with which the Military History of our country abounds. To hold forth these bright examples to the imitation of the youthful soldier, and thus to incite him to emulate the meritorious conduct of those who have preceded him in their honourable career, are among the motives that have given rise to the present publication.

The operations of the British Troops are, indeed, announced in the "London Gazette," from whence they are transferred into the public prints: the achievements of our armies are thus made known at the time of their occurrence, and receive the tribute of praise and admiration to which they are entitled. On extraordinary occasions, the Houses of Parliament have been in the habit of conferring on the Commanders, and the Officers and Troops acting under their orders, expressions of approbation and of thanks for their skill and bravery, and these testimonials, confirmed by the high honour of their Sovereign's Approbation, constitute the reward which the soldier most highly prizes.

It has not, however, until late years, been the practice (which appears to have long prevailed in some of the Continental armies) for British Regiments to keep regular records of their services and achievements. Hence some difficulty has been experienced in obtaining, particularly from the old Regiments, an authentic account of their origin and subsequent services.

This defect will now be remedied, in consequence of His Majesty having been pleased to command, that every Regiment shall in future keep a full and ample record of its services at home and abroad.

From the materials thus collected, the country will henceforth derive information as to the difficulties and privations which chequer the career of those who embrace the military profession. In Great Britain, where so large a number of persons are devoted to the active concerns of agriculture, manufactures, and commerce, and where these pursuits have, for so long a period, been undisturbed by the *presence of war*, which few other countries have escaped, comparatively little is known of the vicissitudes of active service, and of the casualties of climate, to which, even during peace, the British Troops are exposed in every part of the globe, with little or no interval of repose.

In their tranquil enjoyment of the blessings which the country derives from the industry and the enterprise of the agriculturist and the trader, its happy inhabitants may be supposed not often to reflect on the perilous duties of the soldier and the sailor,—on their sufferings,—and on the sacrifice of valuable life, by which so many national benefits are obtained and preserved.

The conduct of the British Troops, their valour, and endurance, have shone conspicuously under great and trying difficulties; and their character has been established in Continental warfare by the irresistible spirit with which they have effected debarkations in spite of the most formidable opposition, and by the gallantry and steadiness with which they have maintained their advantages against superior numbers.

In the official Reports made by the respective Commanders, ample justice has generally been done to the gallant exertions of the Corps employed; but the details of their services, and of acts of individual bravery, can only be fully given in the Annals of the various Regiments.

These Records are now preparing for publication, under His Majesty's special authority, by Mr. RICHARD CANNON, Principal Clerk of the Adjutant-General's Office; and while the perusal of them cannot fail to be useful and interesting to military men of every rank, it is considered that they will also afford entertainment and information to the general reader, particularly to

those who may have served in the Army, or who have relatives in the Service.

There exists in the breasts of most of those who have served, or are serving, in the Army, an *Esprit du Corps*—an attachment to every thing belonging to their Regiment; to such persons a narrative of the services of their own Corps cannot fail to prove interesting. Authentic accounts of the actions of the great,—the valiant,—the loyal, have always been of paramount interest with a brave and civilized people. Great Britain has produced a race of heroes who, in moments of danger and terror, have stood, “firm as the rocks of their native shore;” and when half the World has been arrayed against them, they have fought the battles of their Country with unshaken fortitude. It is presumed that a record of achievements in war,—victories so complete and surprising, gained by our countrymen,—our brothers,—our fellow-citizens in arms,—a record which revives the memory of the brave, and brings their gallant deeds before us, will certainly prove acceptable to the public.

Biographical memoirs of the Colonels and other distinguished Officers, will be introduced in the Records of their respective Regiments, and the Honorary Distinctions which have, from time to time, been conferred upon each Regiment, as testifying the value and importance of its services, will be faithfully set forth.

As a convenient mode of Publication, the Record of each Regiment will be printed in a distinct number, so that when the whole shall be completed, the Parts may be bound up in numerical succession.

HISTORY
OF
THE CAPE MOUNTED
RIFLEMEN;
WITH A
BRIEF ACCOUNT
OF THE
COLONY
OF THE
CAPE OF GOOD HOPE.

ILLUSTRATED WITH DRAWINGS OF THE
STANDARDS
AND THE
COSTUME OF AN OFFICER OF THE CORPS.

LONDON:

JOHN W. PARKER, WEST STRAND.

M.DCCC.XLII.



Madeley lith. 3 Wellington S' Strand.
OFFICER OF THE CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN.
1842.

HISTORY
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The spirit of enterprise which led intelligent Europeans to penetrate to every part of the globe, and to procure the advantage of the productions of every climate for the use of their own country, has multiplied the commerce of the world, and added numerous colonial possessions to the nations of Christendom. Among the enterprising navigators of the fifteenth century, Bartholomew Diaz, a Portuguese officer of sagacity and fortitude, prosecuted a voyage of discovery until he arrived at the lofty promontory which marks the southern extremity of Africa; being prevented by violent tempests from proceeding farther, he called it *Stormy Cape*; but his sovereign, entertaining the hope that this success would lead to the discovery of the long-desired route to the East Indies, called it *the*

1490
1497
1498

Cape of Good Hope. In 1497, Emanuel, king of Portugal, inheriting the enterprising genius of his predecessors, sent Vasco de Gama, a man of talent and noble birth, with three vessels, to pursue the grand scheme of discovering a passage to India by the Cape of Good Hope; and this officer, surmounting the difficulties which had deterred his predecessors, doubled that formidable promontory which had long been the boundary of navigation, and European ships were seen, for the first time, navigating the Indian sea, which forms the greatest event, next to the discovery of America, in modern maritime history. The route to Hindoostan was thus established; but this important event was not immediately followed by the formation of a settlement at the Cape of Good Hope. Admiral Rio d'Infanté landed there in 1498, and fixing upon the mouth of a river for the site of a settlement, recommended his countrymen to establish a colony there; his advice was, however, not followed, and other Portuguese navigators failed in some slight attempts which they made to colonize this interesting part of Africa.

The Cape forms one of the great landmarks of the globe, separating the Atlantic from the Indian Ocean, and dividing the voyage to Hindoostan into two nearly equal portions; the ships of England and Portugal called there, and the Dutch, in the infancy of their Indian trade, fixed upon it as a station for their vessels to take in water and fuel. The English had a custom, in their outward-bound voyages, of burying letters in an iron box, in a place pointed out by a large blue stone, to be taken to England by the first ship calling at the Cape in its way home.

For more than a century the English, Dutch, and Portuguese continued to refresh at the Cape without appropriating the soil; but in 1620 the year 1620, in the reign of King James I., the commanders of two fleets of English ships, bound for Surat and Bantam, took a formal possession of the soil, for, and in the name of their sovereign; this was, however, not followed by the formation of a colony there by the English.

Van Riebeck, surgeon of a Dutch ship that made a short stay at the Cape of Good Hope, represented the richness of the soil, the mildness 1651 of the climate, the advantages which a colony at this place would give his country over other nations whose ships would be obliged to call there; and, above all, the barrier it would afford to the Indian possessions of the United Provinces; these representations induced the Dutch East India Company to

form a regular establishment at the Cape. Van Riebeck was furnished with power to establish a colony, of which he was appointed governor, and three ships, provided with all that was necessary, were placed under his orders. On his arrival at the Cape of Good Hope, the natives surrendered the Cape Peninsula by treaty, with the two bays that are divided by the isthmus, and he erected a square fort, also warehouses, and raised outworks and batteries. Encouragement being given, numbers of settlers arrived from time to time, and, by presents and promises, a larger tract of land was procured; but when the natives saw the colonists building houses and fortifications, cultivating land, and breeding cattle, a feeling of jealousy was awakened, and the Hottentots commenced hostilities for the purpose of expelling their visitors, which ended in the extension of the settlements, the arrival of more troops and colonists from Holland, and the reduction of the natives to a state of dependence little better than slavery.

The Dutch East India Company endeavoured to limit the Cape to the original design of a port for refreshing their ships, and they threw obstacles in the way of its becoming a flourishing settlement; they allowed no trade but what passed through the hands of their own servants, and made it dependent on the governor-general of Batavia, concluding that the settlers would thus be made equally submissive to their orders from Europe, and from the seat of their wealth and influence in the East. This illiberal policy afforded little stimulation to industry; the settlers became conspicuous for habits of indolence, and education being neglected, the manners of the colonists degenerated towards barbarism, united with a cruel propensity to tyrannise over the Hottentots, whose lands they had seized, and from whom they exacted labour without due compensation. A number of French Protestants found an asylum at the Cape, where they introduced the cultivation of the vine; but the colony did not flourish under the Dutch. The natives, however, proved a patient and submissive race; they were the best labourers and herdsmen in the colony, and many of them proved valuable soldiers in the service of Holland.

The declining commerce of the Dutch, towards the close of the eighteenth century, made the Cape a burden to them; little doubt was entertained of their willingness to part with it for a small compensation, and overtures would, probably, have been made from England, but at that period the French Revolution, and its destructive

1794
1795

consequences, unsettled the affairs of Europe. The favourable reception, which the doctrine of equality met with in Holland, having disposed the Dutch to separate from the Allies, with the result of the campaign of 1794 in Flanders, and other causes, occasioned the United Provinces to be brought under the dominion of France. The Prince of Orange fled to England, and he furnished letters authorizing the British to take possession of, and to hold, the colony of the Cape of Good Hope in his name. Many of the colonists had, in the meantime, imbibed French principles; they had become clamorous to declare themselves a free and independent republic; and lists of worthy and influential persons to be consigned to the guillotine, or banished from the colony, for holding different views, were prepared; at the same time the slaves, who were much more numerous than the whites, were holding meetings to decide upon the fate of the free and independent burghers when the period of their own emancipation should arrive. At this important crisis the revolutionists were suddenly disconcerted by the arrival of a British armament under Admiral Sir G. K. Elphinstone, and Major-General James Craig, to take possession of the colony. The governor refused to consign the place to the protection of the British, and ordered the inhabitants to leave Simon's Town. The English were careful not to commit any act of hostility against the Dutch; but it being believed that the governor intended to set fire to Simon's Town, Major-General Craig landed on the 14th of July, 1795, with part of the Seventy-eighth regiment and the Marines of the fleet, and took possession of the place, to preserve it from destruction. Soon afterwards the burgher militia and Hottentot soldiers, who occupied the hills, fired on the British patrols, and hostilities were thus commenced. The Dutch occupied a fortified position on the rocks of Muisenberg, from whence they were driven, on the 7th of August, by the fire of the English ships and the advance of the troops, and two battalions of seamen; on this occasion the advance-guard of the Seventy-eighth regiment drove the enemy from a rocky ridge with great gallantry. The Dutch fell back to Wynberg, a tongue of land projecting from the east side of Table mountain, and about eight miles from Cape Town. On the 4th of September General Alured Clarke arrived with reinforcements, and on the 14th of that month the British advanced and drove the Dutch from their elevated post. Two days afterwards the Dutch governor surrendered the colony to the British arms.

During the following seven years, the Cape of Good Hope remained under the protection of the British Government; and from this period the origin of the CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN may be traced. The Hottentot soldiers were not immediately taken into the British service; but in the years 1796 and 1797, a number of Hottentots presented themselves at the quarters of the light infantry brigade under Major King, of the Eighty-fourth regiment, at the village of Stellenbosch. They were, in the first instance, employed to cook, and perform other menial offices for the soldiers; but their numbers increasing, they were embodied into a corps under Lieutenant John Campbell, of the Ninety-eighth Foot, with a serjeant from the same regiment. Numerous volunteers arriving, additional officers and non-commissioned officers were attached to them, and they were stationed in Hout's Bay, behind Table Mountain.

A rebellion breaking out on the frontiers of the colony, a squadron of the Eighth Light Dragoons, the flank companies of the regiment in garrison, and the Cape Corps, were detached, under Brigadier-General Vandeleur, to suppress the insurrection, and were employed in very arduous duties for some time. At this period, a portion of the Cape Corps was mounted, and employed as orderlies at head-quarters, as guides, and for the carrying of despatches; in performing these duties, they were found very useful.

In 1799, the Cape Corps was again stationed at Hout's Bay, with detachments at Graaff Reinett and Algoa Bay; and, in 1800, this body of men was formed into a regiment under Lieut.-Colonel King, with Major Donald Campbell second in command; the head-quarters were established at Groen Kloof, near Cape Town, under Major Campbell, Lieut.-Colonel King not having joined.

In 1801, the Cape Regiment, except the mounted men, was sent to the frontiers, where it was employed during the year 1802.

At the peace of Amiens, the Cape of Good Hope was restored to the United Provinces, which had taken the name of the Batavian Republic.

When the Dutch governor arrived, in the early part of 1803, with an armament, to take possession, the Cape Regiment was at head-

quarters; it was left in the colony, and nearly every man was retained in the Dutch service.

A few months of respite from war followed the Treaty of Amiens, and, in 1803, the contest was renewed with a violence which, in a few years, shook the basis of every state in Europe. During the first three years of the war, the attention of the British Government was directed to measures rendered necessary by the threatened invasion of England by Buonaparte; but in the latter months of 1805, an armament, consisting of about five thousand men, under the orders of Major-General Sir David Baird^[1], proceeded to recapture the settlement of the Cape of Good Hope, with its dependencies, then in possession of the Batavian Government, and commanded by Lieut.-General Janssens.

After surmounting considerable difficulties, a landing was effected at Lospard's Bay, on the 6th of January, 1806; on the morning of the 8th, the army moved in two brigades towards the road leading to Cape Town, and attacked the enemy's force, consisting of five thousand men, and twenty-three pieces of cannon, advantageously posted at Blaw Berg, or Blue Mountains: the Dutch stood the fire of the invading army with firmness, and maintained their position obstinately; but the charge of the British troops with bayonets proved irresistible, and the enemy was forced to a precipitate retreat.

A negotiation ensued between the two commanders, which was carried on by Brigadier-General (now Lord) Beresford: and the colony was finally surrendered on the 18th January.

In the articles of capitulation it was stipulated, that the battalion of Hottentot Light Infantry should march to Simon's Town, with the other Batavian troops, after which they should be allowed to return to their own country, or to engage in the British Service, as they might feel inclined. A number of them tendering their services, they were formed into a corps at Wynberg, under the command of Lieut.-Colonel Graham, and stationed at that village; a detachment of about fifty men was sent to Fort Frederick, Algoa Bay.

At the period of the surrender of the colony to the British Crown, this regiment consisted, in the first instance, of about five hundred rank and file; and in 1808 it was augmented to eight hundred. Many of the

additional men were procured by native captains, who received two shillings a day; others were procured by recruiting officers, and by small levies on the missionary institutions: a number of volunteers also joined at head-quarters.

At this period, one company was stationed at Graaff Reinett, and another was sent to the frontiers of the colony.

In this and the following year (1809) a company traversed the greater part of the colony, collecting various bodies of Kafirs^[2], and removing them beyond the boundary,—the Great Fish River; this company was followed by others, and in June, 1810, five companies were employed on the frontiers under Major Lyster.

The regiment embarked for Algoa Bay, in September, 1810, and was employed, from December, 1811, until May, 1812, in removing the Kafirs from the country between the Sunday's and the Great Fish Rivers. The command of the force employed on the frontier was confided to Lieut.-Colonel Graham, and the command of the regiment devolved on Major Lyster.

A detachment crossed the Sunday's River on Christmas-day, 1811, under Major Prentice, and encamped at Commando Kraal, from whence parties were sent out to mark roads through the Addo Bush. This work having been completed, the men of the regiment, and some settlers, advanced in extended order to scour the bush. While moving towards the top of the Addo, in a part known by the name of the "Addo Pass," a number of Kafirs, who had hidden themselves in pits, jumped up and commenced throwing their assagais, or javelins, at the troops, killing Field-Cornet Greyling, and wounding two other farmers. The Cape Regiment instantly rushed into the bush, and, after a sharp skirmish, drove the Kafirs from among the trees into the flats or plains.

Landrost Stockenstrom having been murdered while engaged in a parley with the Kafirs, relative to their removing from the Zuurberg, Major Fraser marched with a detachment to execute the orders which were to have been carried into effect by Stockenstrom. On crossing the mountain from Cournay he took a bye-path, and thus escaped a body of Kafirs who were lying in ambush to murder him and his party; and coming upon his adversaries suddenly, he succeeded in killing fifteen of their number; he

also recovered the bodies of Mr. Stockenstrom, two field-cornets, and nine farmers, and buried them; and he ascertained that several Kafirs had been shot in the struggle, when these gentlemen were murdered.

At this period the Chief T'Slambie occupied the Zuurberg with about four thousand Kafirs.

In May the head-quarters were established at Graham's Town, and, in consequence of the hostile attitude of the Kafirs, the regiment was distributed in small parties along the frontier, in two lines of posts; the advanced line in detachments from Osterhuisen's Post, to Old Kafir Drift; the second, from Bruintjie's Hoogte, to what is now called Groen Fontein; in all, about twenty-two posts, the head-quarters remaining at Graham's Town.

Several posts in the rear line were subsequently abandoned, and some of the posts in the front line were occupied by British regiments, the Cape Regiment being found more efficient in patrolling, scouring the bush, and dislodging parties of Kafirs assembled within the colony.

These arduous duties were performed by the regiment in 1813, 1814, and 1815; in the last-mentioned year Major Lyster left the frontier, and the command of the regiment devolved on Major Fraser.

1813
1814
1815

In the year 1815 an extensive revolt took place among the colonists on the frontier, and the Cape Regiment was conspicuously useful on this occasion; its firm and soldierlike bearing checked the revolt; it assisted in the capture of the insurgents; and a hundred men under Major Fraser attended the execution of several convicted delinquents.

After the suppression of this revolt, a detachment of the regiment was selected to be attached to the Royal Artillery as drivers; and in October, two hundred men marched into Kafirland, under Captain Bogle, to recover property which had been stolen by the natives.

In the mean time the war had terminated in Europe, and the sovereignty of the Cape of Good Hope was permanently confirmed to Great Britain by the Congress at Vienna.

In March, 1816, the establishment of the Cape Regiment was fixed at ten companies of three serjeants, two corporals, and fifty private soldiers each; and a further reduction being made in the strength of

1816
1817

the British army, its numbers were reduced, in January, 1817, to six companies, under a major commanding.

During this year, detachments of the regiment were employed night and day in patrolling the Fish River Bush, and repelling the incursions of the Kafirs. In March two lines of posts were directed to be established along the frontier, and the first line, commencing at Upper Kafir Drift and extending up the Fish River as far as Roode Wall, was occupied by the Cape Regiment; at the same time the following orders were issued for its guidance by authority and direction of Lieutenant-General Lord Charles Henry Somerset, then Governor of the Colony.

“It is to be clearly understood that no provocation is to be given to the Kafirs in their own territory. No cattle belonging to any inhabitant or farmer, are, upon any account, to be permitted to stray or graze, over to the Kafir territory; neither is any Kafir to be molested when within his own boundary, nor is any soldier, or other person, permitted to cross the Great Fish River, except when tracing depredations, or in the pursuit of stolen property.

“It will be a primary object to capture any Kafirs trespassing within the limits of the colony, and his Lordship anxiously hopes that this may be effected without bloodshed.

“Should cattle be traced, the party tracing them will, if it consider itself strong enough, and if commanded by an officer, follow until it shall retake them.

“In order to encourage the men employed upon this duty, his Lordship has directed a reward to be given to the party making a capture, of five rix-dollars for each Kafir, not wounded, and one rix-dollar for each head of cattle retaken, and for each head afterwards restored from a Kafir Kraal, in lieu of that which shall have been traced to it.

“Any Kafir who is captured is to be well secured, and conducted from post to post to the Drostdy at Uitenhage.”

In the beginning of April three hundred men under Major Fraser accompanied the Governor, Lord Charles Somerset, to Kafirland, where his

Lordship had an interview with the Chief Gaika, and established friendly relations with that Chief; but the tribes of T'Slambie, Eno, Botman, and Cobus Congo continued hostile to the colony. The advantages resulting from the friendly relations thus established, were followed by the reduction of the regiment to two hundred men, under Major Fraser, who assumed the command of the frontier in October of that year. The hostile clans continuing to make depredations, patrols were out night and day, and on the 10th of October three men of the Cape Regiment, the signal men at Waay Plaats, who were returning from the Cowie Bush, were waylaid and murdered by the Kafirs in a manner which evinced a most barbarous and cruel disposition.

On the 8th of January, 1818, Major Fraser entered Kafirland with an armed force, and sixty men of the Cape Regiment recovered twenty-one horses and two thousand head of cattle from the tribe of T'Slambie. 1818

The Kafirs were not intimidated, but continued their depredations, committing numerous wanton murders, and the Cape Regiment was constantly employed in scouring the bush, at the same time numerous reinforcements of armed Hottentots joined from the several institutions.

At length this border warfare began to assume a more serious aspect, and in April, 1819, the Kafirs under the Chiefs T'Slambie and Lynx made a combined attack on Graham's Town, but were repulsed; on this occasion the conduct of the Cape Regiment was conspicuous, and called forth the approbation of Lieutenant-Colonel Willshire, commanding the troops^[3]. 1819

It was found necessary to pursue these lawless invaders into their own country, and the Cape Regiment, consisting of two troops of cavalry and four companies of infantry, formed part of the force under Colonel Willshire, which advanced into Kafirland in May, and they remained with that force until September, when the Kafirs were completely subdued and brought to terms.

In the year 1820, a number of settlers arrived from Great Britain, and were located about Graham's Town, and in the fine grass country to the south-west of the Fish River. From this period much 1820
1821
1822

improvement was produced in the character of the Colony by the exertions and industrious habits of the new settlers.

The duties of the frontier continued, however, to require activity and vigilance, and in 1823 the Cape Regiment was augmented to four troops of cavalry and four companies of infantry, in order to check the depredations of the Kafirs. 1823

In October of this year Lieut.-Colonel Fraser died, and the command of the regiment devolved on Major Henry Somerset.

The Regiment was actively employed in the border warfare, and on the 4th of December it was engaged with the tribe of the Chief Macomo, when it recaptured many thousand head of cattle, which had been stolen from the farmers along the frontier.

In the years 1824, 1825, 1826, and 1827, the regiment was constantly employed in repelling the inroads of the Kafirs; numerous rencounters took place, and in that period the patrols of the regiment recovered six thousand and twenty-nine head of cattle belonging to the colony, which will give some idea of the nature of this border warfare, and of the arduous duties performed by the corps. 1824
1825
1826
1827

Some respite from these services being afforded, the corps was reduced, in November, 1827, to three companies of mounted riflemen, under a major commanding, and the head-quarters were removed to Fort Beaufort.

THE CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN, under the command of Captain Aitchison, accompanied Lieutenant-Colonel Somerset^[4] into Kafirland, in July and August, 1828, to repel the attacks of a horde of savages, who had driven the border Kafirs into the colony. Lieut.-Colonel Somerset advanced as far as the Umtata River, and on the 28th of August the CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN were engaged with a very superior force of the invading tribes, and after a severe action from day-break until mid-day, the savages retreated, leaving many women and children, and much cattle behind them. 1828

After returning from this enterprise, the RIFLEMEN resumed their duties along the frontier; the depredations of the Kafirs were continued, and in the years 1828, 1829, 1830, 1831, 1832, 1833, and 1834, the patrols of the corps recaptured six thousand two hundred 1829
1830
1831
1832

and ten head of cattle, and three hundred and thirty-four horses, which had been stolen from the colonists. 1833
1834

Disputes frequently arose when the military were searching for lost property; the Kafirs denied the justice of some claims, asserted that seizures were made without proof of guilt, and without the tracks of the lost cattle being traced to the kraal where a demand for cattle in lieu of those lost was enforced. These disputes led to bloodshed, and were followed, in 1834, by a simultaneous attack of the Kafirs upon the colony at all points. On this occasion the CAPE CORPS had three provisional companies of mounted men attached to it, and having taken the field, it was almost constantly engaged in detached parties with the invaders. It penetrated into Kafirland, and was employed in the most active and arduous services under Lieut.-Colonel Somerset, and Major Burney, for many months.

The Kafir war was continued in 1835, and in May of that year the head-quarters of the corps were removed to Cypher Fontein; strong detachments being employed in the new province, and along the line of posts. The corps was also actively employed on the frontier during the subsequent years. 1835
1836
1837

In February, 1838, some of the provisional recruits, stationed at Fort Peddie, laid the foundation of a serious mutiny, which was fortunately discovered by some old soldiers of the corps, and immediately reported to Captain Murray of the Seventy-second Highlanders, commanding the post, and the ringleaders were secured. A party of these men having marched to Fraser's camp, on route to head-quarters, they fired upon their officers in the night, when Ensign Crowe, a provisional officer, was killed. This alarming circumstance appeared to endanger the character of the corps; but the investigation instituted by Major-General Sir George Napier, and the proceedings of the general court-martial on the trial of the ringleaders, clearly proved, that no blame was to be attached to the officers, nor to the established members of the corps: in August, his Excellency the Governor was pleased to recommend a permanent augmentation of three companies to the corps. 1838

The augmentation of the corps was carried into effect in March, 1839, when the six companies of the CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN were placed under the command of Colonel Henry Somerset: their head-quarters 1839

had been removed in the previous November, from Cypher Fontein to Graham's Town, from which period they have been actively employed along the frontier, occupying seventeen posts.

In October, 1840, his Excellency Major-General Sir George Napier inspected the corps, and afterwards, addressing the officers and soldiers, expressed his unqualified approbation of their conduct since he quitted the frontier in 1838, and of their efficiency in every respect.

THE CAPE OF GOOD HOPE, where the services of the CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN have been of signal advantage to the settlers, forms an interesting and important portion of the British dominions, and is capable of becoming a particularly valuable colony. On approaching this part of Africa, the immense mass of naked rock called Table Mountain, rising to the height of three thousand five hundred feet, with its summit covered with a fleecy canopy of clouds, forms a conspicuous object; and on a plain, sloping downwards from the mountain, stands Cape Town, the capital of the colony, which is defended by a castle of considerable strength.

The colony is bounded on the west and south, by the Atlantic and Southern oceans; on the east, by the Great Fish River, which separates it from Kafirland, or Caffraria; on the north by a vast chain of mountains which form a barrier between it and the Bechuanas and other independent tribes that stretch into the interior. The colony is between five and six hundred miles long, and its breadth varies from two to three hundred miles; it contains about one hundred and twenty thousand square miles. The leading features consist of three successive ranges of mountains, running parallel with each other to the southern coast of Africa. Between the first range (called Lang Kloof, or Long Pass) and the sea, there is a belt of land varying from twenty to sixty miles in breadth, covered with a deep fertile soil, watered by numerous rivulets, well clothed with grass and a beautiful variety of trees and shrubs, and yielding an abundance of grain and pasturage. Between this range and the second, called Zwarte Berg, or Black Mountain, there is another belt of land of about the same average breadth, but of greater elevation, and containing patches of fertile land interspersed in large tracts of arid desert; on these spots are a number of grazing farms,

which produce fine horses and horned cattle. Beyond the Black Mountain, at an interval from eighty to a hundred miles of elevated ground of a barren character, rises the highest range of mountains in Southern Africa, called Nieuwveldt Gebrige, the summits of which are generally covered with snow. In this extensive territory, forming, as it were, a succession of terraces rising above each other, much barren land exists, interspersed with many spots of extreme fertility, producing, in their wild state, plants and flowers distinguished by the elegance of their forms and colours. The colony is capable of much improvement, and of maintaining a much larger population than that by which it is occupied. The principal of the rural occupants are wine-growers, corn-farmers and graziers; the first reside in the immediate vicinity of the Cape; they produce wine of ten or twelve different kinds, and that called Constantia, has obtained considerable reputation; brandy also forms a staple product among them, but both articles admit of improvement. The corn-farmers reside, generally, a few days' journey from the Cape, and the fertility of the soil enables them to reap good crops of wheat, barley, rye, maize, peas, beans, and on some occasions they bring quantities of aloes to the Cape, for which they obtain a good price. The graziers occupy the more remote districts of the colony, and have large flocks of sheep, some of them remarkable for immense tails; this breed is, however, gradually becoming extinct; the Saxon, Merino and other fine-wool breeds having been introduced with great advantage; the graziers have also great quantities of horned cattle. Fruits of various kinds are produced on the west coast of the colony in as great perfection as in any part of the globe. The Hottentots are the chief labourers of the colony, and are a patient submissive race; when trained as soldiers they prove an useful and efficient class of men.

Extensive measures have been adopted to diffuse the advantages of civilization, and the blessings of Christianity among the tribes of this part of Africa; schools have been introduced, and missionary stations formed, and the results have been most favourable to the progress of humanity. In this respect the colony offers a field for the efforts of philanthropy of a most interesting character.

The geographical position of the CAPE OF GOOD HOPE points out the importance of this colony in a commercial and military point of view; situate half-way between England and India, in a wholesome climate, and

producing refreshments of every description, it is capable of becoming a particularly valuable post. In the event of a war, the power which holds the Cape may be said to possess the key of India. It is capable of becoming a valuable station for naval and military establishments to give effectual security to the Indian trade and settlements. It might, also, be rendered particularly advantageous to the interests of the British empire as an emporium of Eastern produce, and as furnishing articles of export for consumption in Europe and the West Indies. The advantage of its position, considered in connection with the intercourse of Europe with the vast regions situate around the Indian Ocean, and its convenient situation as a place of refreshment for vessels navigating to and from the East Indies, are quite obvious.

The CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN are intimately connected with the several interesting and important points in which the Cape of Good 1841 Hope may be viewed, in relation to the advantages accruing to Great Britain from the possession of this colony. During the whole of the services of the corps from 1806 to 1841 it has enjoyed, and frequently received, the expressed approbation of the several Commanders-in-Chief of the colony, for its conduct, discipline, and arduous exertions for the service of the Crown. Among the officers who have signalized themselves, the names of *Colonels* John Graham and Henry Somerset; *Lieut.-Colonels* Thomas Lyster and G. Sackville Fraser; *Major* Robert S. Aitchison, and *Captain* William W. Harding, deserve to be particularly mentioned; also, *Lieutenant* and *Adjutant* Robert Hart, who served from 1808 to 1817, when he was appointed to a responsible situation under the Colonial Government; and *Lieutenant* and *Adjutant* John Blakeway, who served from 1819 to 1827. Many of the present members of the corps have shared in all its arduous duties for several years.

In testimony of the high sense entertained by Her Majesty Queen Victoria of the efficient services of the CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN, Her Majesty has recently directed that a pair of Standards, or Guidons, shall be presented to that Corps. The First, or Royal Standard, is of crimson silk; in the centre of which are conjoined the rose, shamrock, and thistle; in a scroll beneath is

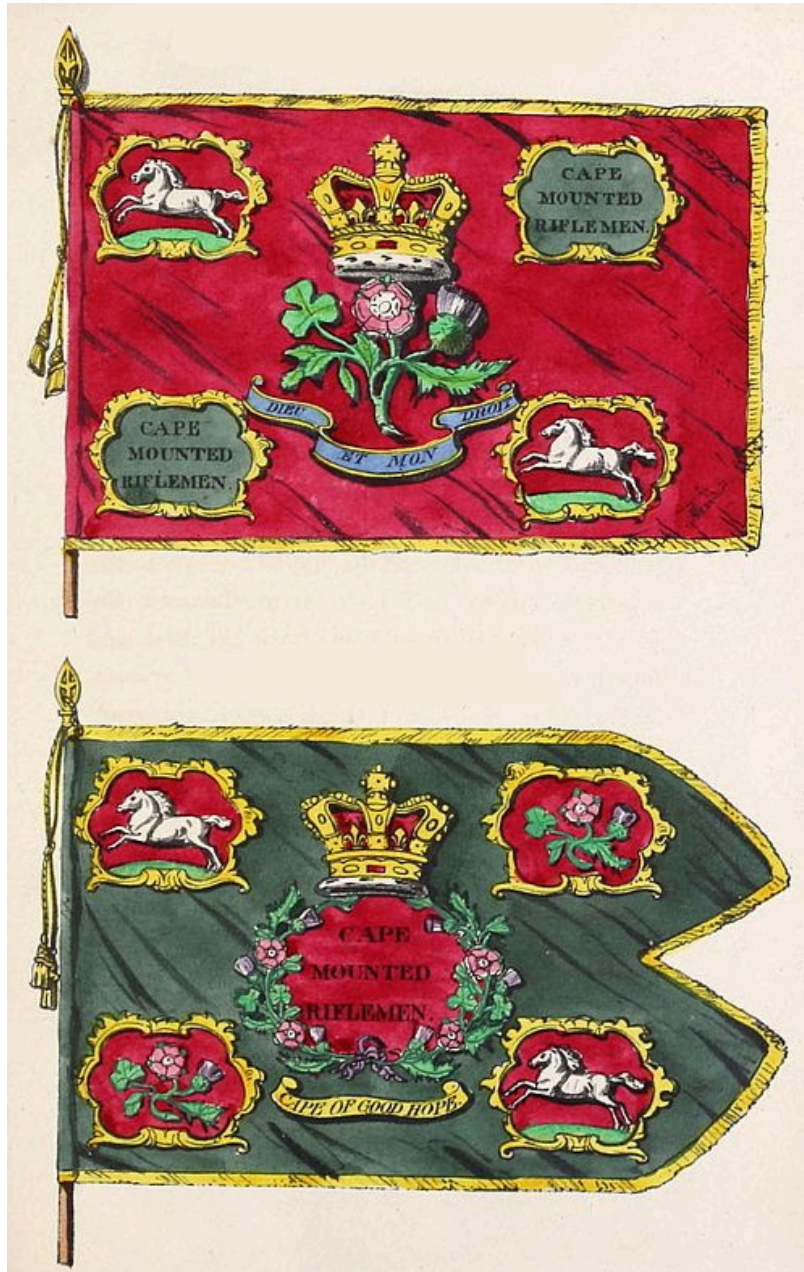
the Royal motto, "*Dieu et mon droit*;" the whole surmounted by the imperial crown; the White Horse on a red ground in a compartment in the first and fourth corners, and the words "*Cape Mounted Riflemen*," on a green ground in the second and third corners. In the middle of the Second, or Regimental Standard, is the title of the Corps encircled by the national emblems of the United Kingdom; above is the imperial crown; and in a scroll beneath the words "*Cape of Good Hope*" in the first and fourth corners the White Horse on a red ground, and in the second and third corners the rose, shamrock, and thistle; the field of this Standard is green; the ground of the four badges is crimson.

So gratifying a mark of the Sovereign's approval cannot fail to prove acceptable both to the officers and men of this useful and efficient corps, and to afford an encouragement to their future exertions and good conduct.

1841

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CAPE MOUNTED RIFLEMEN.



ROYAL STANDARD.
REGIMENTAL GUIDON.

FOOTNOTES:

[1] Corps employed against the Cape of Good Hope, in 1806:—

20th Lt. Drag., (det.)
Royal Artill., (det.)
Royal Engin., (det.)
24th Foot,
38th Foot,
59th Foot,
71st Foot,
72nd Foot,
83rd Foot,
93rd Foot,
Staff Corps, (det.)

The loss sustained in the landing at Lospard's Bay, and in the action of the 8th January, was—1 Captain, (Foster,) 24th Regt., and 14 men killed; 36 men of the 93rd Regt., drowned by the upsetting of a boat in attempting to land; 9 officers and 183 men wounded; and 8 men missing.

[2] The *Kafirs* are natives of *Caffraria*, *Caffreland*, or, more properly, "*Kafirland*," from the Arabic word *Kafir*, which signifies "Unbeliever;" these people are a hardy and warlike race; they are armed with light spears, about seven feet in length, called *assagais*, of which each warrior carries six or eight, and a kind of club for close fighting, called a *kerrie*; the former they throw with great force and dexterity, seldom missing an object at a less distance than sixty paces. The men are, for the most part, tall, muscular, robust, and very active, and from the difficult, and almost inaccessible nature of the country in which the troops have to act against them, are far from being a despicable enemy: they have of late years obtained guns and an abundance of horses; they seldom make an attack in the open field, but select, with much judgment, the most rugged and rocky ravines, and the densest thickets, for their onset. They are patient of hunger and fatigue; and traverse immense distances in an incredibly short space of time, and the features of the country being favourable to their mode of warfare, military combination is rendered extremely difficult; the greatest caution and steadiness are, therefore, requisite in troops employed in any operation, in order to guard against a surprise from so wily and active a people, who are watchful of every opportunity to pounce upon any detachment which may appear to be unsupported, or neglectful of the necessary precautions against surprise.

A most able and experienced officer (Colonel H. G. Smith, late of the Rifle Brigade, and Deputy Quarter-Master-General at the Cape of Good Hope) declared, “that to follow the enemy vigorously to his haunts and lurking-places, requires a perfect knowledge of the service in all its branches, and an intrepidity and recklessness of danger, which, while they become the soldier, prove the courage of the man.”

Although the Kafirs occupy a fertile territory, which is capable of great improvement, yet it is found, even at the present period, that the habits and propensities of the male population are more suited to depredation and warfare, than to the peaceful pursuits of agriculture, the females being employed in all the offices of labour; their frequent incursions on the lands and property of the settlers on the British frontier; their constant state of preparation for aggression and acts of hostility, and the treacherous and, in some instances, barbarous practices to which they have recourse, prove them to be very dangerous neighbours; and until civilization, and the principles of Christianity shall have been diffused in that very extensive territory, it may be apprehended that these people will continue their ravages, particularly if the corps on the frontier should be reduced, or should relax in their responsible duties for the protection of the colony.

Hence the importance of an active and well-disciplined body of troops on the frontier, in which the confidence of the Government can be placed, and which are prepared, on every occasion, to defend the property of the settlers, and to follow up any acts of aggression on the part of their predatory neighbours.

[3] Now Commandant of the Garrison of Chatham.

[4] Lieut.-Colonel Somerset had been appointed Commandant of Caffraria from 25th September, 1825, having been previously employed as Commandant at Simon’s Town and Graham’s Town, from June, 1821.

WEST STRAND, APRIL, 1842.

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